THE HISTORY DEPARTMENT

KEY STAGE 3 MASTER CURRICULUM SERIES

MEDIEVAL ENGLAND & THE STRUGGLE FOR POWER (1066–1485)

From the Norman Conquest and Magna Carta to the Black Death and Bosworth Field



Plate I: The Norman Keep at Portchester Castle, Hampshire (11th–12th Century Roman-Medieval Bastion)

CORE OVERARCHING ENQUIRY:

"How did power shift between Monarch, Church, Barons, and the Common People in Medieval England?"

LESSON	HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & NARRATIVE FOCUS	DISCIPLINARY SKILL & ASSESSMENT FOCUS	PAGE REF
Enquiry 1	1066: The Succession Crisis & The Battle of Hastings	Change & Continuity & The Norman Transition	pp. 2–3
Enquiry 2	Castles, Terror, and the Domesday Book (1066–1087)	Dual-Source Utility & Norman Control Mechanisms	pp. 4–5
Enquiry 3	Crown vs Church: The Conflict of Henry II and Thomas Becket	Causation & The Monarchy-Church Struggle	pp. 6–7
Enquiry 4	Magna Carta (1215): The Great Charter of Liberties	Historical Significance & Limits of Monarchical Rule	pp. 8–9
Enquiry 5	Village Life, Tithes & Doom Paintings (The Manorial World)	Historiographical Debate & Peasant Agency	pp. 10–11
Enquiry 6	The Black Death (1348): Demographic Catastrophe & Serfdom	Turning Point Analysis & The Demographic Crisis	pp. 12–13
Enquiry 7	The Peasants' Revolt (1381): Uprising, Smithfield & Betrayal	Historical Evidence & Working-Class Insurrection	pp. 14–15
Enquiry 8	The Wars of the Roses & The Battle of Bosworth (1455–1485)	Agency & The Collapse of Bastard Feudalism	pp. 16–17

1066: The Succession Crisis & The Battle of Hastings

Key Enquiry: Why did three men claim one throne in 1066, and how did William win? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE SUCCESSION CRISIS & THE DEATHBED PROMISE

[1.1] King Edward the Confessor spent twenty-four years on the English throne being famously pious, politically detached, and disastrously vague about who would succeed him. Having produced no biological heirs, Edward spent his twilight years casually promising the English crown to multiple foreign visitors. When he finally died on 5 January 1066, Anglo-Saxon law provided no clear succession rules, triggering the most vicious three-way geopolitical crisis in English history as rivals gathered across the Channel and North Sea.

[1.2] England's leading earl, Harold Godwinson, acted with ruthless speed. He claimed that as the dying king slipped into unconsciousness, Edward grasped his hand and nominated Harold to protect the kingdom. The Witan —the council of Anglo-Saxon earls and bishops—quickly ratified Harold's claim, crowning him King Harold II in Westminster Abbey the very next morning. Yet Harold's crown rested on fragile ground, as two formidable military commanders immediately denounced him as an illegitimate usurper.

[1.3] Across the Channel, Duke William of Normandy was incandescent with rage. William claimed that Edward had promised him the crown in 1051, and that Harold had sworn a sacred oath on holy relics in 1064 to support William's succession. William secured the backing of Pope Alexander II, who granted a consecrated papal banner. This vital endorsement transformed William's opportunistic cross-Channel raid into a holy crusade against an oath-breaking usurper in the eyes of Christendom.

SOURCE A VISUAL FORENSIC ARTIFACT — c. 1070s • Romanesque Embroidery

The Bayeux Tapestry: Harold's Demise & Senlac Ridge



Commissioned by William's half-brother, Bishop Odo of Bayeux, to celebrate Norman legitimacy while honoring the ferocious courage of English housecarls.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the Norman conquerors choose to depict King Harold fighting bravely rather than cowering as a coward?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 THE NORTHERN PINCER & THE MIRACLE OF STAMFORD BRIDGE

[2.1] Harold faced an agonizing military dilemma: Duke William was assembling an invasion fleet in Normandy, while Viking King Harald Hardrada prepared three hundred longships in Norway. Harold positioned his army along the southern coast throughout the summer of 1066, waiting for the Normans. However, unyielding northerly winds pinned William's fleet in French ports, exhausting English supplies and forcing Harold to disband his peasant militia in early September just as disaster struck.

[2.2] Hardrada's Norse army landed near York, crushing the northern earls at Gate Fulford. Showing astonishing military energy, Harold marched his elite housecarls 190 miles north in just five days, catching the unarmoured Vikings completely by surprise at Stamford Bridge on 25 September. In a savage bloodbath, Hardrada was killed, ending the Viking threat forever. Yet as Harold celebrated in York, a breathless messenger arrived: the Channel wind had shifted, and Duke William had landed at Pevensey.

[2.3] William's fleet had made landfall unopposed on the Sussex coast on 28 September, immediately throwing up a prefabricated timber castle inside the Roman walls of Pevensey. To force Harold into fighting before the English could gather reinforcement levies, William systematically burned and pillaged Harold's personal ancestral estates across Sussex. Taunted by the destruction of his lands and desperate to protect his subjects, Harold made the fatal decision to march south immediately without resting his army.

SOURCE B PRIMARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE Written c. 1066–1067

The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle: The Calamity at Hastings

> *"Then Count William came from Normandy into Pevensey and made a castle at Hastings port. This was made known to King Harold, and he gathered a great army, coming to meet him at the hoary apple tree. And William came against him unawares, before his army was set in order. But the king firmly fought against him... There was slain King Harold, and the French held the place of slaughter."*

Recorded by English monks shortly after the battle, capturing the shock and despair of the defeated Anglo-Saxon population.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the Saxon chronicler emphasize that William attacked "unawares, before his people were set in order"?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

SUCCESSION CRISIS
A dangerous political vacuum caused when a monarch dies without leaving a clear, uncontested biological heir.

THE WITAN
The council of Anglo-Saxon earls and bishops with the ancient constitutional authority to elect and advise the King.

HOUSECARLS
Elite, full-time professional Anglo-Saxon bodyguard warriors trained to swing lethal two-handed Danish battleaxes.

FEIGNED RETREAT
A high-risk military tactic where troops pretend to flee in panic to lure a defensive enemy out of an impenetrable formation.

1066: The Succession Crisis & The Battle of Hastings

ACT 3 SENLAC HILL & THE CLASH OF TWO MILITARY SYSTEMS

[3.1] Harold marched his exhausted army 250 miles back south in under two weeks, arriving at Senlac Hill near Hastings on 14 October 1066. The battle represented a clash between two fundamentally distinct military systems. Harold deployed his troops at the ridge crest, locking heavy lime-wood shields into an impenetrable defensive wall. William commanded a combined-arms force of archers, armored infantry, and devastating heavy cavalry, yet for hours Norman uphill charges broke against the ferocious wall of swinging Danish axes.

[3.2] In the afternoon, panic erupted across the Norman ranks when a rumor spread that Duke William was dead. Norman infantry fled down the slope, and undisciplined Saxon soldiers broke ranks to pursue them. William dramatically pushed back his nasal helmet, shouting: "Look at me! I live, and with God's help I will conquer!" The rallied Norman knights turned and slaughtered the exposed Saxons, exposing the fatal weakness of the stationary Saxon formation.

[3.3] The Saxon shield wall had held firm throughout the morning because the veteran housecarls maintained unbreakable tactical discipline. However, inexperienced peasant fyrdmen could not resist the temptation to chase fleeing enemies down the muddy slope. By breaking ranks, they created fatal gaps in the defensive perimeter. William immediately grasped this tactical vulnerability, ordering his cavalry commanders to repeat the retreat intentionally to dismantle the English defensive formation piecemeal and slaughter the exposed Saxon infantry in the marshy valley below.

KEY FIGURE c. 1028–1087



Duke William of Normandy ("The Conqueror")

DUKE OF NORMANDY (1035–1087) & KING OF ENGLAND (1066–1087)

Conquered England at Hastings, ending 600 years of Anglo-Saxon rule and establishing a centralized Anglo-Norman feudal state.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Secured papal backing with a consecrated papal banner, turning his opportunistic invasion into a holy crusade against oath-breaker Harold.
- Famously pushed back his helmet during the panic on Senlac Hill, shouting: "I live, and with God's help I will conquer!"
- Crowned King of England in Westminster Abbey on Christmas Day 1066 amid smoke and rioting outside the abbey walls.

ACT 4 THE FEIGNED RETREAT, THE FATAL ARROW & THE VERDICT

[4.1] William immediately capitalized on this discovery by ordering repeated "feigned retreats"—charging the hill, pretending to flee in panic, and luring desperate Saxon defenders into the open meadow where heavy cavalry hacked them to pieces. With the English shield wall fatally thinned, William ordered his archers to fire high plunging volleys into the air, raining arrows down behind the remaining Saxon shields while cavalry smashed through the ragged gaps.

[4.2] As dusk fell, King Harold was killed—struck by a fatal missile or butchered by Norman broadswords—and his faithful housecarls died fighting to the last man around his royal dragon standard. Harold had fought two massive battles in three weeks across opposite ends of England, but William's tactical flexibility and devastating heavy cavalry sealed the Norman triumph. On Christmas Day 1066, William was crowned king in Westminster Abbey, formally extinguishing six centuries of Anglo-Saxon political dominance.

[4.3] William's coronation at Westminster Abbey descended into farcical terror when nervous Norman guards mistook loud Saxon cheering inside for armed rebellion, setting fire to all the surrounding thatched houses to form a smokescreen. Yet despite the choking smoke and chaos, William had accomplished the impossible. Through extraordinary fortune with Channel weather, ruthless tactical innovation, and Saxon exhaustion, an illegitimate Norman duke had captured the wealthiest crown in Western Europe, transforming English governance and language forever.

TACTICAL MECHANISM: THE SHIELD WALL BATTLEFIELD CAUSATION • 14 OCTOBER 1066

The Feigned Retreat: Breaking the Shield Wall

The Saxon shield wall was an impenetrable barrier but lacked tactical mobility. When Duke William ordered his cavalry to feign retreat, undisciplined Saxon troops broke ranks down Senlac Hill. The Normans wheeled around, encircled the scattered infantry, and slaughtered them—exposing King Harold and turning stalemate into rout.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: Key Insight: Hastings was decided by Norman combined-arms flexibility exploiting the rigid immobility of the Saxon shield wall.

SOURCE C CONTEMPORARY NORMAN CHRONICLE Written c. 1071

William of Poitiers: The Feigned Flight at Senlac Hill



"The Normans and their allies turned their backs and fled, apparently in panic... The barbarian English, believing the battle won, leapt down from the ridge in disorderly pursuit. Then Duke William and his horsemen wheeled round, hemmed them in on every side, and slaughtered the pursuers without mercy. Thus repeated stratagems wore down the Saxon resistance."

Written by William of Poitiers, Duke William's personal chaplain and military panegyrist, celebrating Norman tactical ingenuity.

HINGE QUESTION: How does William of Poitiers' account highlight the contrast between Norman mounted flexibility and Saxon infantry immobility?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 1 CHANGE & CONTINUITY & THE NORMAN TRANSITION

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Examine both perspectives on Duke William's victory at Hastings: Norman combined-arms tactical flexibility (the feigned retreat) vs King Harold's military exhaustion after Stamford Bridge. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each factor in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** "William's victory was secured by weather and Saxon exhaustion, not Norman military genius." Evaluate this verdict.

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 1 (pages 4–5) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

Castles, Terror, and the Domesday Book

Key Enquiry: How did William the Conqueror establish total control over a rebellious England? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE NORMAN MINORITY & THE WOODEN CASTLE REVOLUTION

[1.1] Following his smoke-choked coronation on Christmas Day 1066, King William faced an immense strategic dilemma. He ruled over two million hostile Anglo-Saxons with fewer than ten thousand Norman soldiers. Surrounded by a sullen, conquered population that deeply resented foreign rule, William could not rely on royal prestige alone. He needed immediate, visible, and terrifying instruments of military dominance that could be erected rapidly across every major town and river crossing in England.

[1.2] William introduced the motte-and-bailey castle—a design previously unknown in England. Using forced Anglo-Saxon peasant labour, Normans threw up massive earth mounds (mottes) topped by wooden palisades, connected to lower enclosed courtyards (baileys). Over five hundred castles were built within two decades. These fortresses served as fortified bases from which armored Norman cavalry could ride out to crush local uprisings, transforming landscape architecture into an inescapable weapon of psychological intimidation.

[1.3] Within years, wooden palisades were replaced by towering stone keeps, such as the White Tower in London and the great rectangular keep at Portchester Castle. Constructed from imported Caen limestone and mortared flint, these monumental stone towers demonstrated permanence. They functioned as impregnable military barracks, administrative courts, and tax-collection headquarters, projecting the Crown's physical dominance and making rebellion against the Norman garrison practically impossible.

SOURCE A PRIMARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE — Written 1087

The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle: Castles & Royal Oppression

> *"King William had castles built, and miserably oppressed the poor people. The King was so very stern, and took from his subjects many marks of gold and many hundreds of pounds of silver... Earls who acted against his will he cast into bonds; bishops he deprived of their sees, and abbots of their abbacies... So stern and relentless was he, that no one dared do anything against his will."*

Written in 1087 as an obituary annal of William I, reflecting the bitter resentment of English monks against Norman military dominance.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the Saxon chronicler link the construction of castles directly with the oppressive taxation and terror of the Norman kings?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 THE HARRYING OF THE NORTH (1069–1070) & TOTAL TERROR

[2.1] When northern earls allied with Danish raiders in 1069, capturing the Norman garrison at York, William responded with terrifying, calculated ferocity. Determined to crush northern resistance forever, he unleashed a scorched-earth campaign known as the Harrying of the North, systematically burning agricultural villages, slaughtering all herds, and salting wheat fields across Yorkshire to ensure zero crops could grow for years.

[2.2] The human toll was catastrophic. Over one hundred thousand people died of starvation and winter exposure; chroniclers recorded refugees eating cats, dogs, and human flesh. Orderic Vitalis lamented that William committed a monstrous crime for which God would surely judge him. Northern England was completely broken and mounted no serious rebellion for three generations.

[2.3] The economic devastation was recorded sixteen years later in Domesday, where vast swathes of Yorkshire were labeled simply as wasta (wasteland). By eliminating the logistical base for invading Scandinavian fleets, ruthless terror secured what diplomacy could not, permanently subordinating the rebellious Anglo-Danish north to the centralized authority of the southern Norman Crown.

SOURCE B CONTEMPORARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE — Written c. 1110–1125

Orderic Vitalis: The Harrying of the North

> *"Nowhere else had William shown such cruelty. In his anger he commanded that all crops, herds, chattels, and food of every kind should be brought together and burned with fire, so that the whole of the north should be stripped of all means of survival. More than 100,000 human beings died of hunger... I can find no words to praise a ruler who caused so many to perish of hunger."*

Written by an Anglo-Norman monk of Saint-Évroul, whose mixed English-Norman heritage gave him a unique moral perspective on Norman brutality.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did Orderic Vitalis—a loyal churchman—break with official Norman propaganda to condemn the Harrying as a monstrous sin?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

MOTTE-AND-BAILEY
An early Norman wooden fortification consisting of a raised earth mound (motte) and an enclosed lower courtyard (bailey).

HARRYING OF THE NORTH
William I's 1069–70 brutal scorched-earth campaign that salted fields and starved 100,000 Yorkshire peasants to crush rebellion.

DOMESDAY BOOK
The unprecedented 1086 nationwide land, population, and wealth audit ordered by William I to maximize royal taxation.

VILLEIN (SERF)
A peasant legally bound to the land of a feudal manorial lord, forbidden to leave or marry without official permission.

Castles, Terror, and the Domesday Book

ACT 3 THE DOMESDAY INQUEST (1085–1086) & ADMINISTRATIVE SURVEILLANCE

[3.1] By Christmas 1085, facing threats of a fresh Scandinavian invasion and an empty treasury, William met his council at Gloucester and ordered an unprecedented national audit. Royal commissioners were dispatched to every shire in England to record who held every parcel of land, what livestock and woodlands existed, and how much annual tax each estate owed the Crown. Sworn juries of English and Norman locals were interrogated under strict royal oaths.

[3.2] Peasants and lords were stunned by the survey's microscopic thoroughness. The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle bitterly complained that not a single ox, cow, or pig escaped inclusion in William's ledger. Completed in August 1086, the resulting Domesday Book recorded two million words across sheepskin parchment. The English nicknamed it "Domesday" because its tax assessments, like the Day of Doom, were completely unalterable, giving the Crown total administrative surveillance over national wealth.

[3.3] The Domesday survey also functioned as an unassailable legal deed for the new Norman ruling elite. Every disputed boundary, mill, fishery, and woodland was settled under the authority of royal commissioners. By compiling these land titles into two massive sheepskin volumes, William proved that bureaucratic ink and systematic documentation could be as devastatingly effective as broadswords in locking an entire nation into royal subservience.

KEY FIGURE 1075–c. 1142



Orderic Vitalis
ANGLO-NORMAN MONK, CHRONICLER & HISTORIAN

Authored the Ecclesiastical History, providing our most searing, vivid critique of Norman brutality and the human toll of the Harrying of the North.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Born in Shropshire to an English mother and a Norman father, giving him a unique dual perspective on the Conquest.
- Wrote candidly that God would punish William for starving 100,000 Yorkshire peasants to death during the Harrying.
- Recorded the meticulous administrative terror of William's tax inquests across the English shires.

ACT 4 THE FEUDAL SETTLEMENT & THE CENTRALIZED STATE

[4.1] William combined physical terror and administrative auditing with a revolutionary restructuring of English land tenure. Declaring that all English soil belonged exclusively to the Crown by right of conquest, William dispossessed virtually the entire Anglo-Saxon aristocracy. By 1086, over five thousand Saxon thegns were replaced by just two hundred Norman barons and bishops, who held their vast estates as feudal tenants-in-chief directly from the King in exchange for military service and knights.

[4.2] In return for these vast estates, barons owed the King feudal loyalty and a fixed quota of fully equipped knights for royal service. At the Oath of Salisbury in August 1086, William forced all major landholders to swear primary allegiance directly to the Crown, superseding any lordly ties. Through stone keeps, the Domesday ledger, and feudal oaths, William created the most centralized and militarily secure monarchy in medieval Europe.

[4.3] At the base of this feudal pyramid, English commoners suffered an immediate, permanent collapse in social status. Free Anglo-Saxon peasants were systematically reclassified as unfree serfs or villeins, bound to the lord's estate and forbidden to leave without costly licenses. Royal justice was reserved for the French-speaking elite, while English peasants endured compulsory week-work, entrenching an aristocratic social hierarchy that endured throughout the entire Middle Ages across all English counties.

INSTITUTIONAL MECHANISM: FEUDAL TENURE ANGLO-NORMAN LAND LAW • 1086

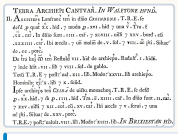
Subinfeudation: Land in Return for Military Service

William the Conqueror confiscated all 20,000 manors in England, claiming total sovereign ownership of the entire kingdom by right of conquest. Under the feudal pyramid, he granted immense estates (fiefs) to roughly 200 Norman tenants-in-chief in exchange for an unalterable quota of armed knights (knight service). These barons subinfeudated parcels to under-tenants, who in turn extracted compulsory agricultural labor from Saxon serfs. Through the Oath of Salisbury in August 1086, William ensured that every landholder swore primary allegiance directly to the King, legally establishing that no lord could command his knights to rebel against the Crown.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: Feudal tenure transformed England from a decentralized collection of earldoms into the most centralized military and fiscal state in Western Europe.

SOURCE C ADMINISTRATIVE MANUSCRIPT Compiled 1086

The Great Domesday Book: Folio 44 (Hampshire Shire Inquest)



"In Fareham, King William holds the manor... There are 30 villeins and 15 smallholders with 18 ploughs. There are 2 mills of 25 shillings, and 3 fisheries of 8 shillings, and woodland for 20 pigs. Its total value in the time of King Edward was £40; now £30."

Written in abbreviated Latin on sheepskin parchment by a single master scribe at Winchester, summarizing two million words of regional inquest data.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did the value of southern manors drop between 1066 and 1086 despite Norman efficiency?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 2 **DUAL-SOURCE UTILITY & NORMAN CONTROL MECHANISMS**

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Compare the mechanisms used by William I to establish control: physical intimidation (motte-and-bailey castles and the Harrying of the North) vs bureaucratic surveillance (the Domesday Book). Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each mechanism in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** Which weapon of control was ultimately more powerful: the Norman castle keep or the Domesday Book?

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 2 (pages 6–7) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

Crown vs Church: The Conflict of Henry II and Thomas Becket

Key Enquiry: Why did the clash between royal law and Church privilege culminate in murder at Canterbury? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE ANGEVIN EMPIRE & THE PROBLEM OF CHURCH JUSTICE

[1.1] When twenty-one-year-old Henry II ascended the English throne in 1154, he inherited the vast Angevin Empire alongside an English kingdom fractured by nineteen years of civil war. Henry was energetic, brilliant, and possessed a legendary temper. He immediately embarked upon an ambitious programme of legal centralization, establishing traveling royal judges, standardizing trial by jury, and asserting Crown sovereignty over baronial courts to guarantee peace across the realm.

[1.2] However, Henry's legal reforms ran straight into the autonomous legal fortress of the Catholic Church. Under the ancient privilege known as "Benefit of Clergy," anyone in holy orders—which included thousands of clerks, gravediggers, and scholars—accused of felonies could only be tried in ecclesiastical courts. Church courts could never shed blood or impose the death penalty, punishing murderers and rapists with mild penances, pilgrimages, or unfrocking, directly insulting royal justice across the English shires.

[1.3] Henry argued that this dual judicial system created a lawless state within a state, where ordained criminals mocked the King's peace with impunity. Royal chroniclers claimed that over one hundred murders had been committed by clerics in the first decade of Henry's reign without a single execution. To Henry, standardizing the law was impossible as long as one-sixth of his male subjects were exempt from secular royal punishment.

SOURCE A PRIMARY DIPLOMATIC DISPATCH — May 1166 • French Exile

Thomas Becket's Admonition to King Henry II

> *"You are my king, you are my lord, you are my spiritual son... The Church of God consists of two orders: the clergy and the people. Kings receive their power from the Church, not the Church from kings. You have no authority to judge the anointed priests of the Almighty, nor to impose your secular customs upon the bride of Christ."*

Written by Becket from exile at the Cistercian Abbey of Pontigny in France, asserting the absolute supremacy of spiritual law over secular royal courts.

HINGE QUESTION: *How did Becket's claim that "kings receive their power from the Church" directly challenge Henry II's royal prerogative?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 THE KING'S GAMBLE & THE ARCHBISHOP'S TRANSFORMATION

[2.1] To bring Church courts under royal control, Henry hatched what seemed a brilliant plan. In 1162, he appointed his closest friend and worldly Lord Chancellor, Thomas Becket, as Archbishop of Canterbury. Becket had been Henry's loyal drinking partner and diplomatic fixer, living in lavish luxury with sixty knights. Henry expected his trusted companion would easily subjugate the English Church to the Crown's legal demands without resistance.

[2.2] Instead, Becket underwent an astonishing, fanatical transformation that shocked the royal court. Upon his consecration, Becket resigned the chancellorship, discarded his silks for a coarse monk's habit, and wore a lice-infested hairshirt. Believing he owed total allegiance to Jesus Christ and the Pope rather than his earthly king, Becket became an intransigent defender of Church autonomy, rejecting royal interference and setting up an explosive collision with his former royal benefactor.

[2.3] Henry felt personally betrayed by his former friend's overnight religious zeal. When Becket adamantly refused to submit ecclesiastical courts to royal judges, Henry realized his masterstroke had backfired disastrously. The King had installed the most stubborn, theatrical, and principled defender of ecclesiastical privilege directly into the most powerful spiritual office in the realm, turning a private friendship into a catastrophic, irreconcilable constitutional conflict.

SOURCE B EYEWITNESS CHRONICLE — 29 December 1170

Edward Grim: The Confrontation in Canterbury Cathedral

> *"The four knights rushed into the church with drawn swords, shouting: "Where is Thomas Becket, traitor to the king?" The Archbishop stepped forward, saying: "Here I am, no traitor, but a priest of God." When they seized his cloak, he pulled away, shouting: "Touch me not, Reginald, you pimp! You owe me fealty!" Then they struck him upon the crown of the head, and his brains were scattered on the altar steps."*

Written by a visiting Cambridge clerk who stood beside Becket during the attack, sustaining a broken arm while shielding the Archbishop.

HINGE QUESTION: *How does Edward Grim's eyewitness account portray Becket as a courageous martyr rather than a frightened victim?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 3

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

BENEFIT OF CLERGY
A medieval legal privilege allowing ordained clerics accused of felonies to be tried in lenient Church courts instead of royal courts.

CONSTITUTIONS OF CLARENDON
Henry II's 1164 sixteen-point royal statute attempting to assert secular Crown supremacy over the English Catholic Church.

EXCOMMUNICATION
The severe spiritual penalty of expulsion from the Catholic Church, cutting off a Christian from the sacraments and salvation.

PAPAL INTERDICT
A papal decree shutting down all church services, baptisms, and Christian burials across an entire rebellious nation.

Crown vs Church: The Conflict of Henry II and Thomas Becket

ACT 3 THE CONSTITUTIONS OF CLARENDON (1164) & BITTER EXILE

[3.1] In January 1164, Henry summoned his bishops to the royal hunting lodge at Clarendon and demanded they sign sixteen articles known as the Constitutions of Clarendon. The core clause insisted that clerics accused of serious crimes must be tried in royal courts after being unfrocked by the Church. Becket initially agreed under extreme baronial intimidation, but soon recanted, claiming that punishing a cleric twice violated God's holy law.

[3.2] Henry's Angevin fury exploded. Put on trial for treason at Northampton Castle, Becket fled into disguise and escaped across the English Channel into French exile. For six agonizing years, the former friends traded insults, excommunications, and papal threats across Europe. Henry banned appeals to Rome and seized Becket's revenues, while Becket threatened to place all England under a papal interdict, shutting down baptisms, weddings, and Christian burials.

[3.3] The feud dragged European monarchs and the Papacy into the dispute. King Louis VII of France sheltered Becket to weaken his Angevin rival, while Pope Alexander III attempted delicate diplomatic mediation. Neither Henry nor Becket would yield: Henry insisted on the ancient customs of his grandfather Henry I, while Becket declared that custom must bow to God's eternal truth, hardening their personal enmity into intractable dogma.

KEY FIGURE 1119/20–1170



Thomas Becket

LORD CHANCELLOR OF ENGLAND (1155–1162) & ARCHBISHOP OF CANTERBURY (1162–1170)

Defended ecclesiastical autonomy against Henry II's legal centralization; his dramatic assassination transformed him into Europe's most revered martyr.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Transformed overnight from a luxury-loving courtier who kept sixty knights into a severe, ascetic monk wearing a lice-infested hairshirt.
- Rejected the Constitutions of Clarendon (1164), asserting that secular royal judges had zero jurisdiction over ordained Church clerics.
- Murdered at the altar of Canterbury Cathedral by four overzealous Norman knights on 29 December 1170.

ACT 4 THE CANTERBURY ASSASSINATION & THE CROWN'S HUMILIATION

[4.1] In late 1170, a hollow truce collapsed when Becket returned to England and immediately excommunicated every bishop who had assisted in crowning Henry's son. Hearing the news during Christmas dinner at Bures, Henry screamed his fateful tantrum: "Will no one rid me of this turbulent priest?!" Four household knights took his words literally, galloped to Canterbury Cathedral on 29 December, and butchered Becket before the high altar, smashing his skull upon the stone floor.

[4.2] The murder sent shockwaves across Christendom, turning Becket into an instant martyr and inflicting an immense public-relations disaster upon the Crown. Pope Alexander III canonized Becket in 1173, and Henry was forced to perform humiliating public penance, walking barefoot through Canterbury to be flogged by eighty monks. While Henry retained common law reforms, Church courts remained independent until the Reformation, proving royal authority had clear limits.

[4.3] Canterbury Cathedral quickly became one of the wealthiest pilgrimage shrines in Europe, as miraculous healings were attributed to Becket's blood. Henry had succeeded in building the English common law and royal jury system, but in attempting to conquer the Church, he created an immortal spiritual martyr. The clash proved that even the most powerful Angevin monarch could not overcome the universal spiritual power of medieval Catholicism.

JURISDICTIONAL CONFLICT: DUAL LEGAL SYSTEMS CANON LAW VS COMMON LAW • 1164

Benefit of Clergy & The Constitutions of Clarendon

In the 12th century, ordained churchmen accused of serious crimes—including murder, theft, and rape—claimed "benefit of clergy," removing their cases from harsh royal justice into lenient ecclesiastical courts. Under canon law, church courts could not shed blood; convicted murderers were merely defrocked, fined, or sent to monastic penance. Henry II's 1164 Constitutions of Clarendon demanded that defrocked clerics be handed over to secular royal judges for hanging. Becket rejected this as double jeopardy ("God does not judge twice for the same offense"), precipitating a mortal constitutional struggle over whether the Crown or Rome held supreme judicial sovereignty in England.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: The Becket dispute was not a petty personal squabble, but a foundational constitutional collision between international papal sovereignty and the nascent English nation-state.

SOURCE C ILLUMINATED MANUSCRIPT RECORD c. 1250

Matthew Paris: The Assassination in Canterbury Transept



"The knights struck with such ferocity that Richard le Breton broke his broadsword on the cathedral flagstones, severing the crown of the Archbishop's head. Monks fled in darkness, while Edward Grim stood fast holding the cross until his arm was shattered. Henry was forced to walk barefoot through Canterbury in sackcloth, allowing eighty monks to flog his bare back with birch twigs."

From the Chronica Majora of Matthew Paris, preserving the visual trauma of Becket's martyrdom for European pilgrims.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was Henry II forced to undergo public flogging if he had never formally ordered Becket's assassination?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 3 CAUSATION & THE MONARCHY-CHURCH STRUGGLE

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Evaluate the motives driving the conflict between Henry II and Thomas Becket: royal legal centralization and the rule of law vs defense of Church autonomy and spiritual liberty. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each perspective in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** "By dying at the altar, Becket won a total victory over the English Crown." To what extent do you agree?

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 3 (pages 8–9) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

Magna Carta (1215): The Great Charter of Liberties

Key Enquiry: Was Magna Carta a selfish aristocratic rebellion or the foundation of modern constitutional law? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE DISASTROUS REIGN OF KING JOHN & THE LOSS OF NORMANDY

[1.1] King John succeeded his legendary brother Richard the Lionheart in 1199, inheriting a bankrupt Angevin treasury and a war-torn empire. John was hardworking, intelligent, and an obsessive administrator, but he possessed a fatal combination of paranoia, cruelty, and appalling military luck. Within five years of taking the throne, John was completely outmaneuvered by French King Philip Augustus, losing Normandy, Anjou, and Maine by 1204 in catastrophic defeats.

[1.2] Losing Normandy earned John the humiliating nicknames "Lackland" and "Softsword," but the domestic consequences were far more toxic. English barons lost their ancestral continental estates, yet John demanded ever-increasing taxes to finance an army of reconquest. John levied eleven scutages ("shield taxes") in sixteen years, seized baronial heirs as hostages, and starved the wife and son of nobleman William de Braose to death in Corfe Castle.

[1.3] John also provoked a bitter dispute with Pope Innocent III by rejecting the appointment of Stephen Langton as Archbishop of Canterbury. In response, the Pope placed England under a devastating six-year Interdict, closing churches and denying Christian burials. John seized Church revenues to enrich his treasury, alienating bishops, nobles, and commoners alike and uniting every sector of English society in profound resentment against royal extortion.

SOURCE A CONTEMPORARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE — Written c. 1214–1215

Roger of Wendover: Baronial Fury against King John

> *"King John was a tyrant rather than a king, a destroyer rather than a governor. He oppressed his own people, seized the inheritances of his barons, and demanded enormous sums of money for their relief. He laid heavy scutages upon the knights, demanded their sons as hostages, and violated the ancient liberties granted by King Henry I. The nobility would endure his intolerable yoke no longer."*

Written by a monk at St Albans Abbey, reflecting the widespread aristocratic outrage that culminated in the May 1215 baronial rebellion.

HINGE QUESTION: *Which specific royal abuses described in Source A were targeted most aggressively by the clauses of Magna Carta?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 THE CATASTROPHE OF BOUVINES (1214) & ARMED REBELLION

[2.1] In 1214, John staked his entire royal fortune on a grand European military coalition to crush King Philip and reclaim Normandy. On 27 July 1214 at the Battle of Bouvines, John's allies were annihilated by the French royal army. John slunk back to England with an empty treasury, shattered military prestige, and zero hope of ever recovering Normandy, only to demand immediate scutage taxes from barons who had refused to fight.

[2.2] England's nobility had reached their breaking point under John's ceaseless extortion. In May 1215, forty rebellious northern and eastern barons took a holy oath, renounced their feudal allegiance to John, and styled themselves the "Army of God and Holy Church." When London's wealthy merchants opened the city gates to the rebels on 17 May, John was completely cornered, cut off from his revenues, and forced to negotiate directly with his armed subjects.

[2.3] Archbishop Stephen Langton acted as chief mediator between the rebellious barons and the isolated Crown. Langton presented the ancient coronation charter of Henry I as a lawful precedent for limiting royal tyranny, drafting a series of reform demands known as the Articles of the Barons. Trapped in Windsor Castle without sufficient money or loyal troops to resist, John agreed to meet the baronial leaders on neutral water-meadows near the River Thames.

SOURCE B CONTEMPORARY DIPLOMATIC ANNAL — 27 July 1214

The Battle of Bouvines: The Ruin of King John's Hopes

> *"At Bouvines in Flanders, the French king Philip Augustus engaged the combined forces of the Emperor Otto, the Count of Flanders, and King John's English knights. By evening, the imperial allies were utterly broken and their leaders captured. When news reached John in Poitou, he threw himself upon his bed, weeping that since he had lost Normandy, fortune had deserted him in everything."*

From the Chronicle of the Kings of France, detailing the decisive battle that destroyed John's military prestige and triggered Magna Carta.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did a military defeat in northern France immediately provoke an armed baronial rebellion in England?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 4

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

SCUTAGE
A financial payment ("shield money") paid by barons to the Crown to excuse them from personal military feudal service.

DUE PROCESS
The fundamental legal principle that no free person can be punished except through fair, lawful judicial proceedings.

SECURITY CLAUSE (CLAUSE 61)
Magna Carta's radical mechanism establishing a council of 25 barons with legal power to seize royal castles if John broke the charter.

ANGEVIN EMPIRE
The vast collection of territories ruled by Henry II and Richard I stretching from the Scottish borders to the Pyrenees.

Magna Carta (1215): The Great Charter of Liberties

ACT 3 RUNNYMEDE & THE REVOLUTIONARY ARCHITECTURE OF THE CHARTER

[3.1] On 15 June 1215, in the waterlogged meadow of Runnymede near Windsor Castle, King John affixed his Great Seal to Magna Carta. Consisting of sixty-three legal clauses drafted on sheepskin parchment, the charter sought to curtail royal extortion regarding feudal inheritance fines, wardships, and arbitrary taxation. Crucially, Clause 12 declared that no scutage or royal aid could be levied except by the "common counsel of the realm," giving barons a constitutional veto over Crown taxation.

[3.2] The most revolutionary provisions established due process and the rule of law. Clause 39 declared: "No free man shall be seized or imprisoned... except by the lawful judgement of his equals or by the law of the land." Clause 40 promised: "To no one will we sell, to no one will we deny or delay right or justice." For the first time, an English sovereign was formally bound by written law.

[3.3] While the charter primarily defended aristocratic property and merchant privileges, its foundational vocabulary introduced universal legal principles. By establishing that justice could neither be sold nor denied, and that punishment required lawful trial by peers, Magna Carta struck a mortal blow against arbitrary sovereign tyranny, providing the enduring constitutional foundation for English common law, individual liberty, and modern parliamentary democracy.

KEY FIGURE 1166–1216



King John ("Lackland" / "Softsword")

KING OF ENGLAND, DUKE OF NORMANDY & LORD OF IRELAND (1199–1216)

His catastrophic military defeats in France and ruthless fiscal extortion provoked the baronial rebellion that forced the sealing of Magna Carta.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Lost the ancestral duchy of Normandy and Anjou to King Philip Augustus of France by 1204, bankrupting the Angevin empire.
- Extorted massive inheritance fines, seized baronial heirs as hostages, and starved the wife and son of William de Braose to death in Corfe Castle.
- Forced to attach his Great Seal to Magna Carta at Runnymede in June 1215, then immediately persuaded the Pope to declare it void.

ACT 4 CLAUSE 61, CIVIL WAR & THE SURVIVAL OF THE CHARTER

[4.1] The barons enforced the charter through Clause 61—the radical "Security Clause"—which established an elected council of twenty-five barons with legal power to seize royal castles and possessions if John breached any clause. Infuriated by this sovereign humiliation, John immediately sent couriers to Pope Innocent III, who issued a papal bull declaring Magna Carta null, void, and shameful forever, excommunicating the rebel barons and plunging England into immediate, bloody civil war.

[4.2] The crisis was resolved only when John died of violent dysentery at Newark Castle in October 1216 after losing the Crown Jewels in the tidal Wash. To save the crown for John's nine-year-old son Henry III, royal regent William Marshal reissued Magna Carta in 1216 and 1225 with papal approval. While originally designed to protect aristocratic privileges, Magna Carta established the enduring constitutional principle that royal authority is limited by law and subject to the consent of the realm.

[4.3] Over the following two centuries, English kings were forced to reconfirm Magna Carta more than thirty times in exchange for parliamentary taxation. What began as a selfish baronial peace treaty became the sacred touchstone of English constitutional liberty. Kings could rule as majestic sovereigns, but they could never again rule above the sovereign supremacy of the law without facing legitimate baronial resistance from the assembled realm.

CONSTITUTIONAL TURNING POINT: RULE OF LAW THE RUNNYMEDE CHARTER • JUNE 1215

Clause 39 & The Invention of Due Process

The most enduring provision of Magna Carta was Clause 39: "No free man shall be seized or imprisoned, or stripped of his rights, except by the lawful judgment of his equals or by the law of the land." King John had routinely imprisoned political rivals without indictment, seized baronial lands without trial, and sold justice to the highest bidder. While the 1215 charter primarily protected the property of twenty-five rebel barons, Clause 39 established the radical constitutional principle that royal power was subordinate to the law. In later centuries, this clause evolved into trial by jury, habeas corpus, and universal constitutional liberty.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: Magna Carta began as an elitist baronial treaty, but permanently bound the English monarchy to the principle of institutional restraint and due process.

SOURCE C CONSTITUTIONAL PARCHMENT ARTIFACT 15 June 1215

The British Library Magna Carta: Cotton MS Augustus II.106



"Clause 39: No free man shall be seized or imprisoned, or stripped of his rights or possessions, or outlawed or exiled... except by the lawful judgment of his equals or by the law of the land.
Clause 40: To no one will we sell, to no one will we deny or delay right or justice."

One of four surviving exemplars issued from the Runnymede chancery under King John's Great Seal, establishing the immortal principle that the monarch is subject to the law.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was written Latin parchment on sheepskin necessary to bind the king rather than a sacred spoken oath?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 4 HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE & THE LIMITS OF MONARCHICAL RULE

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Analyze both interpretations of Magna Carta: a selfish, reactionary rebellion by wealthy feudal barons vs the foundational cornerstone of English due process and the rule of law. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each view in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** Was Magna Carta a selfish power grab by wealthy barons or a genuine foundation of universal human rights?

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 4 (pages 10–11) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

Village Life, Tithes & Doom Paintings

Key Enquiry: How did the open-field system, the parish Church, and fear of Hell shape everyday peasant existence? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE MANORIAL FRAMEWORK & THE OPEN-FIELD RHYTHM

[1.1] In medieval England, over eighty-five percent of the population lived in small rural villages known as manors, where daily survival was dictated by the unrelenting rhythm of the agricultural seasons. Most villagers were serfs or villeins—peasants legally bound to the soil who could not leave the estate, marry, or educate their sons without purchasing permission from the manorial lord. Feudal law granted them land to farm in exchange for mandatory labor.

[1.2] Peasants farmed using the open-field system, dividing village arable land into two or three colossal communal fields. Each family worked scattered, narrow strips within these vast fields, sharing ox teams and heavy wooden mouldboard ploughs. While this strip distribution ensured nobody monopolized the richest soil, it required total village conformity. In addition to their own strips, villeins performed mandatory "week-work" ploughing and harvesting the lord's private demesne estate.

[1.3] Daily village justice was administered through the manorial court, presided over by the lord's bailiff. Villeins were regularly fined for minor infractions, from letting pigs wander into the lord's corn to brewing sub-standard ale. Yet the manor also provided essential community cohesion: common pasture allowed peasants to graze livestock, while the village hayward and reeve ensured that agricultural work was synchronized across the entire settlement.

SOURCE A PRIMARY MANORIAL RECORD — Compiled c. 1300

Custumal of the Manor of Battle Abbey: Feudal Services

> *"Every villein who holds a virgate of thirty acres must do two days of week-work every week from Michaelmas to Lammas, ploughing and harrowing the lord's demesne with his own oxen. At harvest time, he must provide three men to reap the lord's corn for four days. He may not sell his horse or marry his daughter without the lord's license, and must pay three pence for pannage of his swine."*

From an official manor roll recording the exact unfree labor obligations owed by serf families to the Benedictine monks of Battle Abbey.

HINGE QUESTION: *How does this manorial custumal demonstrate that feudal serfdom was fundamentally an economic system of compulsory labor?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 THE TITHE BARN & THE ECONOMIC MIGHT OF THE PARISH CHURCH

[2.1] At the physical and spiritual center of every medieval village stood the stone parish church. The Catholic Church was not merely a spiritual sanctuary; it was an immense economic corporation that owned one-third of England's agricultural land. Under church law, every peasant was legally obligated to pay a compulsory annual "tithe"—one-tenth of all agricultural produce, including wheat, barley, wool, eggs, piglets, and fruit.

[2.2] Tithe collection was supervised by the manorial reeve, and the grain was stored inside colossal stone "tithe barns" beside the rectory. Failure to pay was treated as a grave sin punishable by spiritual excommunication and damnation. In addition to tithes, peasants paid "mortuary fees" (surrendering their finest beast upon death) and fees for baptisms, marriages, and burials, generating immense wealth for bishops and monasteries while keeping peasants on subsistence margins.

[2.3] Despite these financial exactions, the parish church was the social heart of rural existence. Church festivals, saints' days, and holy holidays provided peasants with welcome relief from relentless physical toil. Parishioners celebrated "church-ales" to raise funds for church maintenance, while the churchyard served as the village gathering place for trading, news, and community celebrations under the watchful eye of the parish priest.

SOURCE B PRIMARY ECCLESIASTICAL STATUTE — Promulgated c. 1287

Statutes of the Diocese of Exeter: Enforcement of Tithes

> *"We strictly command all parishioners under pain of greater excommunication that they faithfully render unto their parish church the full tenth sheaf of all corn, the tenth fleece of wool, the tenth piglet, and the tenth penny earned by craft or trade. Let no man presume to deduct his expenses before paying God his share, lest his crops be blighted and his soul damned to eternal fire."*

Issued by Bishop Peter Quivel of Exeter, warning peasant villagers that withholding tithes from the Church was a mortal sin against God.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the medieval Catholic Church use threats of "eternal fire" to enforce what was essentially a civil agricultural tax?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 5

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

OPEN-FIELD SYSTEM
The agricultural system where peasant villagers farmed scattered narrow strips of land across two or three huge communal fields.

TITHE
A compulsory tax of one-tenth (10%) of all agricultural crops, livestock, and wool paid annually to the parish Church.

DOOM PAINTING
A dramatic, terrifying mural painted on the chancel arch depicting Christ judging souls into Heaven or the mouth of Hell.

DEMESNE
The land on a medieval manor kept by the lord for his own private use and farmed using compulsory peasant labor.

Village Life, Tithes & Doom Paintings

ACT 3 THE VISUAL SERMON & THE TERRORS OF THE HELLMOUTH

[3.1] Because Sunday church services were conducted entirely in Latin—a language ordinary peasants could not understand—the Church communicated its theological doctrine through vivid, terrifying visual storytelling. Medieval churches were not bare stone; their walls were covered from floor to ceiling in dazzlingly colored frescoes, stained-glass windows, and carved wooden rood screens depicting biblical history, horrific martyrdoms, and the lives of the holy saints.

[3.2] The most dramatic visual centerpiece was the Doom Painting, emblazoned across the high chancel arch above the altar. Dominating the mural was Christ seated upon a rainbow as universal judge. While angels escorted pious souls into the golden New Jerusalem, hideous horned demons dragged chains of shrieking sinners down into the "Hellmouth"—a fiery, fanged serpentine monster. Corrupt merchants, dishonest bakers, and unfaithful priests were depicted being boiled in cauldrons.

[3.3] These vivid murals served as inescapable visual sermons for illiterate villagers. By illustrating the horrific eternal tortures awaiting sinners—from pitchfork-wielding demons skinning the deceitful to serpents gnawing the proud—Doom paintings reinforced moral codes. Every villager understood that their earthly conduct, obedience to authority, and faithful payment of tithes determined their eternal fate between heavenly paradise and demonic torment in the world to come.

KEY FIGURE 13th–14th Century



The Manorial Reeve

PEASANT SUPERVISOR & VILLAGE FOREMAN OF THE LORD'S DEMESNE

Elected by his fellow serfs but answerable to the bailiff, the reeve balanced the daily survival of villagers against the lord's demands.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Supervised compulsory week-work, ensuring peasants ploughed, sowed, and harvested the lord's strips before tending their own.
- Inspected tithe deliveries to the parish church, ensuring every tenth sheaf of wheat was delivered to the rector's barn.
- Reported village infractions to the manorial court, from stray pigs rooting in barley to brewers selling sour ale.

ACT 4 SPIRITUAL ANXIETY, PURGATORY & FEUDAL OBEDIENCE

[4.1] To medieval peasants, Hell was not a distant metaphor; it was an immediate, terrifying reality. The Church taught that almost all souls lingered for centuries in the agonizing fires of Purgatory to purge their sins before entering Heaven. The only way to shorten this suffering was through the spiritual machinery of the Catholic Church: purchasing papal indulgences, paying priests to say requiem masses, going on holy pilgrimages, and showing unquestioning obedience.

[4.2] This pervasive spiritual anxiety reinforced the feudal social hierarchy. Peasants were taught that God had ordained the three estates of medieval society: those who fight (the nobility), those who pray (the clergy), and those who work (the peasantry). Rebelling against your manorial lord was portrayed as a mortal sin against God's divine order, ensuring that fear of eternal damnation kept England's agricultural majority docile and compliant for centuries.

[4.3] This powerful synthesis of economic obligation and spiritual dread formed the bedrock of medieval stability. As long as commoners believed that manorial lords held earthly power by divine providence and priests held the keys to eternal salvation, the feudal social order was self-policing. Not until the catastrophic biological shock of the Black Death would this ancient framework of rural obedience begin to crack and collapse under sudden labor scarcity.

AGRARIAN SYSTEM: MANORIAL ECONOMY MEDIEVAL SERFDOM & STRIP FARMING

The Open-Field System & The Manorial Court Roll

Peasant village agriculture relied on three vast open fields farmed in scattered half-acre strips, ensuring no single family held only fertile or waterlogged soil. Crops were rotated annually between wheat, barley, and fallow to restore soil fertility. Every peasant was bound to the manorial court, where the lord's bailiff enforced compulsory labor services (corvée), collected marriage fines (merchet), and punished encroachments. However, court rolls prove that peasants were not passive victims; villagers used the sworn manorial jury to negotiate custom, protect communal pasture rights, and sue neighbors for boundary disputes.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: The medieval manor was simultaneously a harsh system of feudal exploitation and a cooperative community sustained by rigid communal consensus.

SOURCE C MEDIEVAL FRESCO c. 1470

The Doom Painting: St Thomas Becket Church, Salisbury



"Painted across the chancel arch above the altar, this massive mural showed peasants exactly what awaited them at the Last Judgement. Demons with claws and horns haul chains of naked souls—including kings, bishops, and alewives—directly into the fiery maw of Hell, while angels usher the faithful into the golden New Jerusalem."

Painted in chalk and earth pigments; during the Reformation it was whitewashed over, only to be rediscovered in 1881.

HINGE QUESTION: How did the Church use visual art to control a population that could not read Latin?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 5 HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE & PEASANT AGENCY

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Examine the structures governing medieval peasant life: economic exploitation under the manorial open-field system vs spiritual and psychological control through parish tithes and terrifying Doom paintings. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each structure in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** How did fear of Purgatory and Hell reinforce the feudal social hierarchy of medieval England?

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 5 (pages 12–13) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

The Black Death (1348): The Great Pestilence

Key Enquiry: How did the catastrophe of 1348 dismantle the foundations of feudal serfdom? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE ARRIVAL AT MELCOMBE REGIS & THE MEDICAL VOID

[1.1] In June 1348, a merchant vessel from Gascony docked at the Dorset port of Melcombe Regis, carrying fine wines and a lethal passenger: the Oriental rat flea (*Xenopsylla cheopis*), harboring the deadly bacterium *Yersinia pestis*. Within days, local townspeople developed agonizing egg-sized swellings (buboes) in the groin and armpits, followed by black necrotic spots, continuous vomiting, and excruciating death within seventy-two hours. The Great Pestilence had arrived on English shores.

[1.2] Fourteenth-century medical knowledge was completely powerless. Physicians operating under ancient Greek humoral theory believed the plague was caused by "miasma"—poisonous foul air generated by earthquakes and planetary alignments. Doctors advised patients to burn aromatic herbs, sit over open cesspits to inhale latrine vapours, or apply shaved chickens to buboes. With zero understanding of bacterial infection or flea transmission, the epidemic swept rapidly across English counties like wildfire.

[1.3] Religious terror accompanied the physical horror. Believing the plague was divine retribution for England's vanity and sin, towns held penitential processions while fanatical flagellants whipped themselves until blood soaked their tunics. Yet neither pious prayer nor bizarre medical potions halted the contagion. As whole households perished behind barred doors, the social fabric began to disintegrate under the weight of sudden, universal mortality.

SOURCE A PRIMARY ROYAL STATUTE — Promulgated June 1351

The Statute of Labourers: King Edward III

> *"Because that a great part of the people, and especially of workmen and servants, late died of the pestilence, many seeing the necessity of masters and great scarcity of servants, will not serve unless they may receive double or triple the wages they were wont to take... We have ordained that every workman shall be bounden to serve, receiving only the wages accustomed in the twentieth year of our reign."*

Enacted by Parliament in Westminster to prevent surviving peasants from exploiting the post-plague labor shortage to demand higher wages.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why were the royal penalties of the Statute of Labourers largely ineffective against the economic reality of supply and demand?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 DEMOGRAPHIC COLLAPSE & THE BREAKDOWN OF SOCIETY

[2.1] By the summer of 1349, the contagion engulfed London, killing hundreds of citizens daily. Across England, between thirty and forty-five percent of the entire population died within eighteen months—roughly two million human beings out of five million. Entire villages were wiped out; parish cemeteries overflowed, forcing authorities to dig colossal mass trenches where corpses were stacked like layers of timber. The psychological trauma shattered normal Christian funeral rituals.

[2.2] The catastrophic mortality produced an unprecedented economic shockwave across the kingdom. With nearly half the agricultural workforce dead, England faced an acute, desperate shortage of human labour. Thousands of acres of ripe wheat rotted in rain-drenched fields; herds of cattle wandered unmilked across weed-choked meadows, and manorial lords faced total financial ruin. Surviving peasants suddenly realized their labor was in immense demand, transforming the balance of economic power overnight.

[2.3] Traditional authority fractured under the strain of sudden mortality. Monasteries lost whole communities of monks, while hundreds of parish priests abandoned their dying flocks in terror or perished administering last rites. In the countryside, surviving serfs recognized that land without labor was worthless, giving humble ploughmen unprecedented bargaining leverage over proud landlords and fatally undermining compulsory feudal serfdom.

SOURCE B CONTEMPORARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE — Written c. 1350

Henry Knighton: The Devastation of Leicestershire

> *"In that year there was a great mortality of men throughout the whole world... Sheep and cattle wandered through fields and among crops, and there was none to drive them or herd them; for lack of servants, wheat rotted in the rain. So great was the scarcity of priests that many churches were left desolate without divine service... A worker who could previously be hired for two pence now refused to work for less than five pence."*

Written by an Augustinian canon at Leicester Abbey, documenting the immediate agricultural collapse and peasant empowerment.

HINGE QUESTION: *How does Knighton's description show that the Black Death damaged the authority of both manorial lords and the Catholic Church?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 6

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

BUBONIC PLAGUE
A lethal bacterial infection caused by *Yersinia pestis*, transmitted by black rat fleas and causing swollen, agonizing buboes.

MIASMA THEORY
The prevailing medieval medical belief that infectious diseases were caused by poisonous, foul vapors rising from rotting matter.

STATUTE OF LABOURERS (1351)
A harsh parliamentary law passed by landowning lords attempting to freeze peasant wages at pre-plague 1346 levels.

DANSE MACABRE
The post-plague cultural motif ("Dance of Death") showing personified Death dancing with popes, kings, and peasants alike.

The Black Death (1348): The Great Pestilence

ACT 3 THE WAGE REVOLUTION & THE STATUTE OF LABOURERS (1351)

[3.1] Surviving villeins and farmhands abandoned their deference. Peasant laborers refused to work on manorial demesnes unless lords paid double or triple their pre-plague wages. When conservative lords attempted to enforce ancient unfree labor services, peasants simply packed their belongings and walked to neighboring estates where desperate landowners competed to offer high cash wages, better food, and free tenancy, ignoring traditional feudal restrictions on freedom of movement.

[3.2] Horrified by this insubordination, England's landlord-dominated Parliament passed the emergency Ordinance of Labourers in 1349, followed by the landmark Statute of Labourers in 1351. The law made it a crime for any worker to demand, or any employer to pay, wages higher than pre-1348 levels. Laborers who left their villages were branded on the forehead with a hot iron "F" for falsity, creating intense working-class resentment that simmered for decades.

[3.3] To enforce the statute, royal justices of the peace were appointed in every county to hold labor sessions and fine rebellious workers. Yet economic reality proved stronger than royal decrees. Manorial lords quietly paid illegal bonuses and offered meat allowances to secure reapers, recognizing that without workers their estates would return to wilderness, rendering parliamentary wage caps practically unenforceable across rural England.

KEY FIGURE — Died c. 1396



Henry Knighton

AUGUSTINIAN CANON OF ST MARY DE PRATIS ABBEY, LEICESTER

Eyewitness chronicler of the Black Death; recorded both the horrifying mortality rate and the sudden economic empowerment of surviving labourers.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Documented the terrifying speed of bubonic and pneumonic infection as it swept through Leicestershire in 1348–49.
- Recorded the agricultural standstill: unharvested wheat rotting in rain-soaked fields and cattle wandering through towns.
- Wrote indignantly of surviving peasants who refused to work unless paid double or triple their pre-plague wages.

ACT 4 THE COLLAPSE OF SERFDOM & THE PSYCHOLOGICAL SHIFT

[4.1] Despite harsh statutory punishments and royal fines, economic market forces defeated parliamentary legislation. Lords needed crops harvested, and secretly paid higher wages regardless of royal decrees. The Black Death permanently shattered the economic foundation of feudal serfdom. Over the following century, unable to command free labor, lords abandoned direct farming of demesnes, dividing their estates into tenancies and allowing villeins to purchase their legal freedom with cash.

[4.2] The pestilence also provoked a profound psychological crisis. The Catholic Church, which claimed to mediate God's protection, lost thousands of parish priests who fled infected parishes or died alongside their flocks. Untrained substitute clergy damaged Church prestige, while the Dance of Death (*Danse Macabre*) art movement emerged, celebrating the chilling truth that death took kings, popes, and serfs alike, sowing the seeds of modern individualism.

[4.3] By demonstrating that aristocratic blood and holy orders provided zero immunity against pestilence, the Black Death fundamentally eroded peasant deference. Survivors inherited multiple family holdings, ate wheaten bread instead of rye, and wore finer wool. The rigid three estates of feudalism had been irreversibly compromised, setting the stage for direct confrontation between an empowered working class and the ruling aristocracy in 1381.

EPIDEMIOLOGICAL SHOCK: CAUSAL ETIOLOGY — MEDIEVAL MEDICINE & DEMOGRAPHY • 1348

Miasma, Astrology & Divine Wrath: Explaining Pestilence

Without germ theory, medieval society explained the arrival of the Black Death through three prevailing frameworks: corrupted air (miasma), celestial alignment, and divine punishment. Doctors believed malodorous vapours from rotting corpses, swamps, and earthquakes unbalanced the bodily humours, prompting people to carry posies of aromatic herbs. Astrologers blamed a planetary conjunction of Saturn, Jupiter, and Mars in Aquarius. Devout Christians viewed the epidemic as God's retribution for human vanity, sparking extremist Flagellant movements who marched through towns whipping themselves with iron-tipped cords to appease divine fury.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: The total failure of Church prayers and Galenic medicine to halt the Black Death severely cracked medieval blind faith in traditional institutional authorities.

SOURCE C ILLUMINATED CHRONICLE — c. 1350

Gilles li Muisis: Mass Plague Burials in Tournai



"No bells tolled, and no one wept; for almost all expected death... People said and believed: 'This is the end of the world.' So many died that trenches had to be dug in cemeteries and bodies piled forty deep. A dead man was then of no more account than a dead goat."

From the Annals of Abbot Gilles li Muisis, documenting the psychological collapse and breakdown of Christian funeral rites.

HINGE QUESTION: How did the collapse of normal burial ceremonies shatter medieval religious certainty?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 6 — TURNING POINT ANALYSIS & THE DEMOGRAPHIC CRISIS

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Assess the transformative impact of the Black Death: immediate demographic and social devastation vs the long-term empowerment of surviving peasants and the decay of feudal serfdom. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each consequence in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** "The Black Death destroyed the feudal system far more effectively than any army." Assess this judgement.

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 6 (pages 14–15) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

The Peasants' Revolt (1381): The Great Uprising

Key Enquiry: Why did the common people march on London, and did their bloody rebellion transform England? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 WORKING-CLASS GRIEVANCE & THE THIRD POLL TAX (1381)

[1.1] By 1381, England was a boiling cauldron of working-class grievance. For three decades following the Black Death, rural peasants had endured the humiliating wage caps of the Statute of Labourers while fighting an expensive, failing war against France. To fund costly military garrisons in Gascony and Brittany, the regency council of fourteen-year-old King Richard II devised a deeply hated new levy: the Poll Tax, an aggressive flat-rate charge levied on every adult over fifteen.

[1.2] Unlike traditional property taxes, the third Poll Tax of 1381 demanded a uniform twelve pence (one shilling) from rich and poor alike—representing two full weeks' wages for a farmhand. Peasants across England evaded the census, claiming village populations had mysteriously halved. When royal tax commissioners were dispatched into rural villages to uncover tax evaders with threats of physical torture, the rural commons resolved to resist by force of arms.

[1.3] Radical social ideas fanned the flames of revolt. In Essex and Kent, radical priests such as John Ball traveled between village markets, preaching that all men were born equal under God and that feudal hierarchy was an unjust human invention. Ball's revolutionary rhyming couplet —"When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"—resonated powerfully with working people who felt exploited by corrupt royal ministers and grasping manorial lords.

SOURCE A CONTEMPORARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE — Written c. 1381–1385

The Anonimalle Chronicle: The Outbreak at Fobbing

> *"On the morrow of the Holy Trinity, John Bampton, justice of the king, sat at Brentwood to inquire into the Poll Tax of the hundred of Barstable. The men of Fobbing came before him and said they would not pay a penny more, for they had already paid their tax and held their acquittance. When Bampton threatened them with prison, they drew their bows and threw stones at him, so that he fled for his life back to London."*

Written in Anglo-Norman French by a monk at St Mary's Abbey, York, preserving the earliest eyewitness account of the 1381 uprising.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the aggressive methods of royal tax commissioners trigger immediate armed rebellion in Essex villages?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

ACT 2 THE SPARK AT FOBBING & THE MARCH ON LONDON

[2.1] In May 1381, armed violence erupted in the Essex village of Fobbing when villagers attacked royal tax collector John Bampton, driving him out under a shower of stones. Rebellion spread rapidly across Essex and Kent under the charismatic military leadership of roof-tiler Wat Tyler. Joined by radical itinerant priest John Ball—who famously preached: "When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"—sixty thousand armed rebels converged upon London.

[2.2] Sympathetic London apprentices and poor citizens threw open the city gates on 13 June. The peasant army rampaged through the capital with disciplined fury: they burned the Savoy Palace of hated royal uncle John of Gaunt, destroyed tax records, executed corrupt royal judges, and stormed the Tower of London, dragging out Archbishop Simon Sudbury (the King's Chancellor) and beheading him on Tower Hill after eight messy axe blows.

[2.3] The capture of the Tower was an astonishing humiliation for the royal government. The most formidable fortress in the kingdom had fallen without a siege, captured by peasants armed with scythes and rusty swords. The rebels targeted symbols of administrative oppression: they burned manorial rolls in the streets and destroyed the legal records of the Temple, determined to erase every written document that proved their legal servitude.

SOURCE B RADICAL SERMON EXCERPT — Preached 12 June 1381

John Ball's Sermon at Blackheath: Universal Equality

> *"Ah, ye good people, matters goeth not well to pass in England, nor shall not do till everything be common, and that there be no villeins nor gentlemen, but that we may be all united together, and that the lords be no greater masters than we be. When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman? From the beginning all men by nature were created alike, and our bondage came in by the unjust oppression of naughty men."*

Recorded in the Chronicles of Jean Froissart; preached to 60,000 peasants camped at Blackheath before they marched into London.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why was John Ball's sermon considered an act of catastrophic religious heresy and treason by medieval authorities?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 7

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

POLL TAX
A flat-rate direct tax levied on every individual adult regardless of wealth, triggering universal working-class fury in 1381.

SUMPTUARY LAWS
Parliamentary statutes regulating the clothing, furs, and food different social classes were legally permitted to consume.

MANORIAL ROLLS
Vellum legal court registers recording the names, land debts, and villeinage obligations of peasants, burned by 1381 rebels.

EGALITARIANISM
The radical political philosophy preached by John Ball asserting that all human beings are created naturally equal by God.

The Peasants' Revolt (1381): The Great Uprising

ACT 3 THE MILE END CONCESSIONS & THE SMITHFIELD STANDOFF

[3.1] Fourteen-year-old King Richard II took shelter in the Tower before agreeing to meet the rebel leaders at Mile End on 14 June. Demonstrating remarkable maturity, Richard conceded to all their demands, issuing sealed royal charters promising the complete abolition of serfdom and freedom of trade throughout the realm. Satisfied by these royal promises, thousands of moderate Essex rebels laid down their pitchforks and dispersed toward their villages.

[3.2] However, radical Kentish rebels under Wat Tyler demanded far more. On 15 June, Richard met Tyler at the Smithfield cattle market outside the city walls. Tyler demanded the confiscation of all Church lands, the division of aristocratic property, and total legal equality for all Englishmen. During tense negotiations, Tyler spat insolently at the King's feet, prompting Mayor William Walworth to draw his dagger and strike Tyler down in the mud.

[3.3] As Tyler slumped dying from his saddle, the rebel ranks erupted in fury. Thousands of archers notched arrows to their bowstrings, preparing to slaughter the King and his small aristocratic escort. It was the most dangerous moment of the English Middle Ages; the entire Plantagenet dynasty stood seconds away from annihilation at the hands of an enraged peasant army on the outskirts of London.

KEY FIGURE Tyler (d. 1381) • Ball (c. 1338–1381)



Wat Tyler & John Ball

LEADERS OF THE 1381 GREAT UPRISING

Led England's first major popular revolution, capturing London and demanding the total abolition of serfdom and equality under the law.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- John Ball preached radical equality at Blackheath: "When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"
- Tyler led 60,000 peasants from Kent and Essex into London, burning the Savoy Palace and executing the King's treasurer.
- Met King Richard II at Mile End and Smithfield, demanding the end of villeinage and freedom of trade across England.

ACT 4 ROYAL BETRAYAL, BLOODY RETRIBUTION & THE VERDICT

[4.1] On 15 June 1381 at Smithfield, Wat Tyler met the young King Richard II in full view of the royal retinue. Tyler boldly demanded total freedom for all Englishmen, the abolition of all game and forest laws, the confiscation and division of all Church lands among the peasantry, and the complete destruction of aristocratic hierarchy. When an altercation erupted, the Mayor of London, William Walworth, drew his cutlass and struck Tyler down.

[4.2] The royal retaliation was swift, brutal, and completely merciless. King Richard II and his council reneged on all promises made at Mile End and Smithfield, declaring that concessions made under duress were completely void. Royal judicial commissions toured Essex and Kent with mobile gallows, hanging over one thousand five hundred suspected rebel leaders, including John Ball, whose severed head was displayed on London Bridge as a terrifying warning to all commoners.

[4.3] Yet despite the bloody suppression of the rebel vanguard, the Peasants' Revolt achieved a profound, lasting psychological victory. Parliament never dared to levy another direct poll tax for three hundred years. Shaken by the vulnerability of their London palaces and the ferocity of working-class anger, manorial lords gradually allowed villeinage to wither away, recognizing that attempting to enforce feudal serfdom risked provoking fresh, uncontrollable peasant uprisings across the realm.

POLITICAL CATALYST: FISCAL EXTORTION THE 1381 MARCH ON LONDON

The Three Poll Taxes & The Demand for Freedom

Between 1377 and 1380, the royal government levied three unprecedented Poll Taxes to finance the Hundred Years' War. Unlike taxes on property, the 1380 Poll Tax was a flat regressive charge of twelve pence on every person over fifteen—equating to two weeks' wages for poor laborers. Across the southeast, communities concealed 450,000 taxpayers in massive tax evasion. When royal commissioners used coercive enforcement, rebellion exploded. Led by Wat Tyler and radical priest John Ball, 60,000 peasants marched on London demanding the complete abolition of serfdom and equality under the law.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: The Peasants' Revolt proved that the post-plague English peasantry understood statutory law and would not tolerate feudal re-enslavement by an extractive aristocracy.

SOURCE C ILLUMINATED CHRONICLE c. 1470s

Jean Froissart: The Murder of Wat Tyler at Smithfield



"Tyler said to the King: 'Thinkest thou that I will take thy word?' The Mayor of London drew his sword and struck Tyler such a blow on the head that he fell from his horse to the ground... The King said: 'Sirs, will you shoot your King? I am your captain, follow me!'"

From the Chronicles of Jean Froissart, an aristocrat-friendly chronicler who portrayed the peasants as unruly beasts.

HINGE QUESTION: How does Froissart's wealthy background bias his description of Wat Tyler's actions?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 7 HISTORICAL EVIDENCE & WORKING-CLASS INSURRECTION

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Evaluate both historical interpretations of the 1381 Peasants' Revolt: an unruly, chaotic outburst of working-class violence vs a sophisticated, coordinated political movement demanding legal equality and an end to feudal serfdom. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each view in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** Did the Peasants' Revolt achieve anything, or was it an utter failure crushed by royal betrayal?

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 7 (pages 16–17) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

The Wars of the Roses (1455–1485): Dynastic Catastrophe

Key Enquiry: How did aristocratic rivalry, bastard feudalism, and Richard III bring the medieval era to a close? • *Acts 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 A CATATONIC KING & THE CURSE OF BASTARD FEUDALISM

[1.1] The Wars of the Roses (1455–1485) were a thirty-year series of bloody civil wars fought between two rival branches of the royal Plantagenet dynasty: the House of Lancaster (symbolized by the red rose) and the House of York (the white rose). At the core of the catastrophe was the personal inadequacy of King Henry VI. Gentle and devout, Henry suffered complete catatonic mental breakdowns, staring blankly at walls for over a year.

[1.2] Medieval England could not tolerate a monarch incapable of leading troops into battle. Into this power vacuum stepped overmighty aristocratic magnates practicing "Bastard Feudalism." Instead of traditional feudal land dues, wealthy lords used immense fortunes to pay cash retaining fees, raising private liveried armies wearing noble badges. Magnates used these armed retainers to intimidate royal judges, violently settle private feuds, and treat the English Crown as a prize to be seized.

[1.3] The rivalry between Queen Margaret of Anjou—defending her infant son's Lancastrian succession—and Richard, Duke of York—asserting superior dynastic descent—shattered royal authority. With no strong king to arbitrate baronial feuds, noble families like the Nevilles and Percys took up arms. In May 1455 at St Albans, street fighting erupted into open civil war, initiating three decades of aristocratic carnage that decimated England's ancient noble houses.

ACT 2 THE TOWTON SNOWSTORM (1461) & THE KINGMAKER'S GAMBIT

[2.1] The dynastic conflict escalated into unprecedented aristocratic savagery. On Palm Sunday 1461, at the Battle of Towton in Yorkshire, Lancastrian and Yorkist armies clashed amidst a blinding snowstorm. Over twenty-eight thousand men were slaughtered in ten hours of hand-to-hand combat—the bloodiest single day ever recorded on English soil. Towton swept nineteen-year-old Yorkist commander Edward IV onto the English throne, temporarily exiling the Lancastrian royal family.

[2.2] However, aristocratic loyalties proved notoriously fickle. Edward IV soon alienated his greatest champion, Richard Neville, Earl of Warwick—known to history as "The Kingmaker." Warwick switched sides, deposed Edward IV, briefly restored the bewildered Henry VI, and was finally killed fighting Edward at Barnet in 1471. When Edward IV died suddenly in 1483, he left behind twelve-year-old Edward V under the guardianship of his ambitious uncle, Richard, Duke of Gloucester.

[2.3] Edward IV's second reign appeared to restore stability, but it rested upon fragile dynastic foundations. By murdering Henry VI in the Tower and ruthlessly hunting Lancastrian heirs, Edward had normalized the violent removal of monarchs. When he died unexpectedly at forty-one, leaving a minor heir and a divided court, the machinery of aristocratic usurpation roared back into action with lethal consequences.

SOURCE A PRIMARY EYEWITNESS DISPATCH — Written Autumn 1483

Dominic Mancini: The Disappearance of the Princes

> *"All the attendants who had served the young king Edward V were forbidden his presence... He and his little brother Richard were withdrawn into the inner apartments of the Tower day by day, and through the bars and windows could be seen less and less, until they ceased to be seen altogether. Already there were suspicion and whispers among the people that they had been done away with; and men wept openly in the streets of London."*

Written by an Italian cleric visiting London during Richard III's usurpation, offering an objective eyewitness report devoid of Tudor bias.

HINGE QUESTION: *How did the disappearance of the Princes in the Tower fatally undermine Richard III's moral legitimacy as king?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

SOURCE B CONTEMPORARY MONASTIC CHRONICLE — Palm Sunday 1461

The Crowland Chronicle: The Bloodbath at Towton

> *"On the day of the Passion of our Lord, the armies of York and Lancaster met in the fields near Towton in Yorkshire. A blinding blizzard of snow blew directly into the faces of the Lancastrians, so that their archers could not see their targets. The slaughter continued without pity for ten hours; the waters of the Cock Beck ran thick with red blood, and the bodies of twenty-eight thousand Christian Englishmen lay unburied upon the snow."*

From the second continuation of the Crowland Abbey Chronicle, recording the horrific human cost of bastard feudalism and civil war.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why does the chronicler specifically emphasize that "twenty-eight thousand Christian Englishmen lay unburied"?*

Curriculum Primary Record — Department Archives

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 8

KEY STAGE 3 VOCABULARY

BASTARD FEUDALISM
The late-medieval practice where wealthy lords paid cash retaining fees to contract private armies of liveried soldiers.

LIVERY AND MAINTENANCE
The unlawful aristocratic practice of providing private badges to thugs and intimidating royal judges to protect retainers.

USURPATION
The act of seizing the sovereign royal throne by military force or conspiracy without a direct lawful hereditary claim.

TUDOR SETTLEMENT
The political compromise in 1485 where Henry VII married Elizabeth of York, combining the rival roses and ending civil war.

The Wars of the Roses (1455–1485): Dynastic Catastrophe

ACT 3 THE PRINCES IN THE TOWER & RICHARD III'S USURPATION

[3.1] Richard of Gloucester acted with ruthless decisiveness. Intercepting the royal entourage, Richard seized young Edward V and escorted him to royal apartments in the Tower of London, joined by his younger brother Richard, Duke of York. Within weeks, Richard declared his nephews illegitimate, executed prominent rivals without trial, and had Parliament offer him the crown as King Richard III in July 1483 amidst murmurs of aristocratic dread.

[3.2] Late that summer, the two young princes vanished behind the Tower's thick stone walls, never to be seen alive again. Contemporary rumours that Richard had smothered his nephews under feather mattresses alienated loyal Yorkist allies across southern England. Rebellions erupted, uniting disillusioned Yorkists and exiled Lancastrians behind an obscure twenty-six-year-old Welsh nobleman living in exile in Brittany: Henry Tudor, Earl of Richmond.

[3.3] Richard III was a courageous warrior and capable northern administrator, but the dark shadow of usurpation fatally poisoned his reign. Aristocratic trust evaporated; noblemen who had fought for the House of York could not stomach a sovereign widely suspected of murdering innocent royal boys. Richard's court became an armed camp of paranoia, setting the stage for a desperate final showdown upon the battlefield.

KEY FIGURE 1452–1485



King Richard III

LAST PLANTAGENET KING OF ENGLAND (REIGNED 1483–1485)

His usurpation of the throne and the mysterious disappearance of the Princes in the Tower alienated Yorkist allies, leading to his dramatic death at Bosworth.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Served loyally as Lord of the North for his brother Edward IV, establishing a reputation for military courage and fairness.
- Seized the young Edward V on his way to his coronation in 1483, declared his nephews illegitimate, and took the crown for himself.
- Cut down in a desperate, ferocious cavalry charge targeting Henry Tudor at the Battle of Bosworth Field on 22 August 1485.

ACT 4 BOSWORTH FIELD (1485) & THE TUDOR DAWN

[4.1] On 22 August 1485, the medieval era ended in blood at the Battle of Bosworth Field. Outnumbered two to one, Richard III drew up his army on Ambion Hill. But half his force—commanded by Lord Thomas Stanley—stood aloof, waiting to see who would prevail. Spotting Henry Tudor lightly guarded in the rear, Richard launched a ferocious, suicidal cavalry charge directly into Tudor's bodyguard, cutting down Henry's standard-bearer within feet of Henry's throat.

[4.2] At that decisive moment, Lord Stanley unleashed his three thousand fresh troops into Richard's exposed flank. Dragged from his horse into the marsh, Richard was hacked to death, his gold battle circlet knocked off and later retrieved from a thorny hawthorn bush. Crowned on the field as Henry VII, the new Tudor king married Elizabeth of York, united the rival roses into the Tudor rose, banned private noble armies, and established an authoritarian modern renaissance monarchy.

[4.3] The Battle of Bosworth Field on 22 August 1485 marked the definitive end of the Plantagenet dynasty and the dawn of the early modern era. Crowned King Henry VII on the battlefield, the new Tudor monarch married Elizabeth of York, uniting the warring red and white roses into the Tudor rose. Henry systematically outlawed private livery and maintenance, heavily fined unruly magnates, and established the Court of Star Chamber, ending bastard feudalism and securing the English throne.

STRUCTURAL MECHANISM: BASTARD FEUDALISM DYNASTIC COLLAPSE • 1455–1485

Livery and Maintenance: Private Noble Armies

The dynastic bloodbath of the Wars of the Roses was driven by "bastard feudalism"—a late medieval corruption of traditional land tenure. Instead of granting land in exchange for military service, wealthy magnates like the Earl of Warwick ("The Kingmaker") paid annual cash retaining fees (indentures) to hundreds of gentry. In return, retainers wore the lord's heraldic livery badge and fought in his private army. Through "maintenance," magnates illegally bribed and intimidated judges and juries to protect their retainers from criminal prosecution. With weak kings incapable of enforcing royal justice, England fractured into warring private armed factions.

KEY HISTORICAL INSIGHT: Bastard feudalism privatized military violence, proving that monarchy collapses whenever private aristocratic wealth overpowers the Crown's monopoly on justice.

SOURCE C RENAISSANCE BATTLE RECORD Published 1534

Polydore Vergil: The Death of Richard III at Bosworth Field



"King Richard, alone, was killed fighting manfully in the thickest press of his enemies... He rushed into the midst of the foe, killed William Brandon the standard-bearer, unhorsed John Cheney, and fought hand to hand until overwhelmed by numbers. Henry was proclaimed king on the field with Richard's battered crown."

Commissioned by King Henry VII (Henry Tudor) to record official Tudor history; highly critical of Richard's tyranny but unable to deny his battlefield valour.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was it vital for Henry VII to portray Richard III as an illegitimate monster rather than an anointed king?

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT • ENQUIRY 8 **AGENCY & THE COLLAPSE OF BASTARD FEUDALISM**

TASK 3: EVIDENCE PREPARATION Weigh the causes behind the collapse of the Plantagenet dynasty during the Wars of the Roses: structural corruption through Bastard Feudalism and private noble armies vs personal ambition, dynastic usurpation, and Richard III's loss of legitimacy. Note two key pieces of factual evidence for each factor in your workbook.

TASK 4: EXTENDED WRITING **Enquiry Question:** Why is the Battle of Bosworth Field (1485) considered by historians to mark the end of the Middle Ages in England?

→ **Pupil Workbook:** Turn to Lesson 8 (pages 18–19) in your Pupil Workbook to complete your Task 3 evidence notes and Task 4 written response.

KEY CHRONOLOGY & CAUSAL TURNING POINTS: 1066–1485

Master Revision Spine • Key Stage 3 Master Curriculum Series

CHRONOLOGICAL SPINE • 19 CAUSAL TURNING POINTS (1066–1485)

1066 Edward the Confessor dies; Harold Godwinson wins at Stamford Bridge but is killed at Hastings; William crowned king.

1067–1071 Over 500 motte-and-bailey castles built across England; William crushes English rebellions with ruthless force.

1069–1070 The Harrying of the North: William salts fields and starves 100,000 Yorkshire peasants to eliminate rebellion.

1086 The Domesday Book is compiled, auditing all land, wealth, and livestock; William takes the Oath of Salisbury.

1154 Henry II ascends the throne, creating the Angevin Empire and establishing the English Common Law and trial by jury.

1164 The Constitutions of Clarendon spark a bitter constitutional clash between Henry II and Archbishop Thomas Becket.

1170 Thomas Becket is assassinated before the altar of Canterbury Cathedral by four Norman knights; Henry performs penance.

1204 King John loses Normandy and ancestral Angevin territories to King Philip Augustus of France.

1214 John's grand European coalition is crushed at the Battle of Bouvines, shattering royal finances and prestige.

1215 Rebellious barons force King John to seal Magna Carta at Runnymede, establishing the rule of law and due process.

1258–1265 Simon de Montfort leads a baronial rebellion against Henry III, summoning the first parliament with burgesses.

1295 Edward I summons the "Model Parliament", establishing the principle that taxation requires parliamentary approval.

1348–1350 The Black Death kills 30–45% of England's population, triggering an acute labor shortage and empowering peasants.

1351 Parliament passes the Statute of Labourers in a failed attempt to freeze wages at pre-plague rates.

1381 The Peasants' Revolt: Wat Tyler and John Ball lead armed commons to capture London; Poll Tax abolished.

1455 The Wars of the Roses begin: First Battle of St Albans pits the House of Lancaster against the House of York.

1461 Battle of Towton: Over 28,000 men killed in a snowstorm; Yorkist Edward IV seizes the crown.

1483 Edward IV dies; Richard III seizes the throne; the Princes in the Tower mysteriously disappear.

1485 Battle of Bosworth Field: Richard III killed in battle; Henry VII crowned, founding the Tudor dynasty.

THE 4 BIG STORYLINES TO TRACK • CORE DISCIPLINARY STRANDS

Monarchy & Sovereignty
The Crown asserted absolute Divine Right through castles, administrative inquests, and common law, but was continuously checked by rebellion.

Faith & The Church
The Catholic Church owned one-third of English soil, levied compulsory tithes, and maintained autonomous courts independent of the king.

Baronial Resistance
From Magna Carta to the Wars of the Roses, wealthy magnates used armed rebellion and bastard feudalism to restrain or depose royal tyrants.

Peasant Agency
Surviving serfs exploited the demographic shock of the Black Death and the 1381 uprising to dismantle feudal villeinage through market forces.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE: HOW POWERFUL WAS THE MEDIEVAL ENGLISH CROWN?

The Centralist Interpretation (F.W. Maitland & J.E.A. Jolliffe)
"Argues that the Norman Conquest established a uniquely centralized, bureaucratic monarchy unmatched in Europe, where the royal writs, exchequer auditing, and common law courts held undisputed legal sovereignty over the realm."

The Revisionist Feudal Reality (K.B. McFarlane & David Carpenter)
"Emphasizes that medieval royal power was inherently fragile and consensual. Lacking a standing army or police force, a king was completely dependent on baronial cooperation, and autocratic rule inevitably invited deposition or civil war."

SYNOPTIC ASSESSMENT & HISTORICAL VERDICT: THE MEDIEVAL STRUGGLE FOR POWER

Legal Centralisation vs Royal Tyranny
Common law, circuit judges, and exchequer rolls gave England unmatched administrative coherence, yet extortionate taxation and arbitrary rule repeatedly provoked armed baronial revolt.

Secular Prerogative vs Papal Supremacy
Clashes between Henry II and Becket or John and Innocent III proved that the Crown was never sovereign in isolation—the Catholic Church held absolute moral and judicial authority.

Demographic Catastrophe & Social Emancipation
Neither royal statutes nor aristocratic force could halt the economic empowerment of laborers after the 1348 Black Death, permanently eroding feudal serfdom by 1485.

DISCIPLINARY WRITING FRAMEWORK • CAUSAL & EVALUATIVE ARGUMENTATION

1. Causal PEEL Structure & Evidence:
"A decisive catalyst for the baronial challenge was... for example, following [Date], [Barons/Crown] instituted [Action], which directly compelled..."

2. Counter-Argument & Nuance:
"However, this factor cannot be viewed in isolation; chronic financial extortion and battlefield failure in France fundamentally destabilised..."

3. Synoptic Historical Verdict:
"Ultimately, while royal administrative institutions provided coercive machinery, baronial consensus remained the true foundation of medieval governance..."

INTERACTIVE REVISION HUB • 20-QUESTION KNOWLEDGE PRACTICE QUIZZES

ENQ 1	ENQ 2	ENQ 3	ENQ 4	ENQ 5	ENQ 6	ENQ 7	ENQ 8
1066 & Hastings	Castles & Domesday	Henry II & Becket	Magna Carta 1215	Village Life & Tithes	Black Death 1348	Peasants' Revolt 1381	Wars of the Roses
INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ